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Charles fair has new food, finalizes renovations

Ilana Williams iwilliams@somdnews.com

Sep 3, 2025

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Glenn Belmore, president of the Charles County Fair, walks around the fairgrounds and talks about the people County Fair opens on Sept. 11.

Ilana Williams/Southern Maryland News

For some, a county fair can be summed up like this: Hundreds of volunteers, a few paid staff and a lot to see in four days.

The Charles County Fair is set to open on Thursday, Sept. 11, at 4 p.m. and runs through Sunday, Sept. 14. It will have its usual agricultural events, entertainment, carnival rides and exhibitions like glass blowing and pig races. But it will also have a few new things and policies.

One of the changes will be the \$100,000 expansion of the south gate house. It used to have three ticket booths, but has now grown to eight booths. Money from the project came from ticket sales, previous fairs and other events in recent years.

“I’ve probably got two dozen people that are always working to make this better,” Glenn Belmore, president of the Charles County Fair, said. “We’re here for the community.”

The fairgrounds has been going through a lot of renovations over the years, Belmore said. The farm and garden building used to have open rafters, but now has a ceiling to make them more usable year round.

Then in 2013, there was a fire at the fairgrounds, Belmore said. When they reopened they had new buildings, including a large indoor space that can host weddings, sporting events and gun shows off season. During the fair, people will show off their livestock.

“[It’s] pretty awesome to see this little 7-year-old handling a 200-pound hog,” Belmore said. “You watch them do it and they’re good at it.”

Fair directors also started putting people’s names on a brick walkway in the Old MacDonald Barn, Belmore said. During the fair, it will have agricultural displays, including a scale that was used to weigh tobacco.

For the fair itself, Felix and Fingers Dueling Piano will be part of the entertainment, Belmore said. The board also decided to keep the stick pony races they brought back for the 100th anniversary last year.

“The food here is really good,” Belmore said. “We’re not just an old county fair. We’ve moved up.”

The board is also bringing back fresh roasted peanuts and worked with the Charles public school system to have a school bus that was transformed into a mobile kitchen as an additional food vendor.

The food competition will include out-of-county judges and a student judge for the first time because “kids like different foods,” Belmore said.

Last year, the fair had 55,000 visitors and is expecting that many this year, Belmore said. Thursday will be half-price entry night with unlimited carnival rides being \$20 per person, no coupon required.

“When you’re doing a good thing, it shows,” Belmore said. “And by the people coming here ... that [shows] we’re doing the best.”

The Fair Queen’s dinner is on Sept. 5, a “working day” is scheduled for Sept. 7 and the fair will be open for exhibits to set up on Sept. 10.

Visitors 17 and younger must be accompanied by a chaperone who is at least 21-years-old to be admitted or remain on the grounds during the fair after 5 p.m. Tickets for adults and kids 11 and older are \$10 per day. Children 10 and under are free.

All parking on the fairgrounds is free, but it is strongly recommended to use satellite parking at the Charles County courthouse and government building in La Plata where shuttle bus service will be available.

For more information about activities and getting to the fair, go to charlescountyfair.com.
